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Struggle for change in a Nubian community

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Section Title(S): LIFE-CYCLE CEREMONIES

Dancing recommenced near sunset, the two families involved in the wedding each slaughtered a sheep, and still another procession moved from the groom's to the bride's house amid great shouting, gunshot, and drumming. (In earlier times there was at this point a mock battle between the two families in which the groom and his escort were thrashed with whips.) Before entering the house, the groom was greeted by the bride's family and offered sweetened water or milk symbolizing a happy wedded life for the couple. As he and his friends watched from an honored place, from time to time signaling for perfume to be sprinkled on the guests, singing and dancing continued outside the house.

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Organized Ceremonial

At this time the bride—newly bathed, dyed with henna, and wearing new underclothing, a colored gallabeya with a blue dress over it, two colored veils, and a white shawl—awaited the groom in the decorated bridal chamber, which was divided into two parts. The bride stayed behind a curtain that would remain up for forty days after the wedding and was attended by a special slave who brought her food and drink, dressed and undressed her, and generally looked after her needs during her period of seclusion. In the front of the chamber the groom received his guests during this period.

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During the evening, the groom and a few of his friends were permitted to penetrate the bride's chamber by means of a ritual in which they attempted first to bribe the slave guarding the door with a few coins but finally forcing entry into the bride's presence. As the groom burst through the door, the bride's mother spat on him and splashed him with milk, symbolizing the bride's purity, then demanded payment for allowing him into the room. After more bargaining, he gave a few coins, but the bride still refused him permission to see her face on this first night. After the refusal, he touched her forehead with his sword, pulled off her white shawl, spread it on the floor, knelt upon it and prayed. In some districts, he then sprayed Nile water over her veiled face from his mouth, and, placing his foot upon her, made several slight incisions in the calf of her leg. Before leaving the chamber, the groom and his friends scattered 41 millet and sometimes dates over the bride to promote life and fertility, then passed the night in another room joking until morning. Several of the friends and relatives of the bride joined her in her own chamber through the night since consummation of the marriage had to await the next day.

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